

Irony And Tension: A New Critical Reading Of Azunwo's *Rabbi*

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ABSTRACT

The paper, "Irony and tension: a new critical reading of Azunwo's Rabbi", discusses the issues of conflicts of interest operating at the corporate level between a church General Council of pastors led by Pastor Tobi and an individual, Pastor Oscar. The play also touches on a domestic conflict, between a husband and a wife over the former's inadequate attention to the family. Both issues are achieved through utterances in dialogues that embody contradictions, ambiguities, and complexities in the linguistic devices of irony and tension, both tenets of New Criticism. The paper adopts close Reading and qualitative analysis of the text, Rabbi, in identifying the linguistic devices and showing how they express the themes of the play. Invariably, this methodology involves the tenets of the theoretical framework of New Criticism. The paper concludes that Azunwo successfully deploy is the contradictions in the literary devices of irony and tension to reveal the themes of the play, thereby plugin illiteracy cap and contributing to knowledge.

The play, *Rabbi* written by Eziwho Emenike Azunwo is about the tension and contradiction between group interest and personal interest, secrecy and revelation, loyalty and rebellion, personal interest and family interest, pursuits of spiritual calling and denial of matrimonial needs.

Tension is the linking together of opposites. It is created by the integration of the abstract and the concrete, of general ideas embodied in specific images (Tyson, 123).

The plot of the six-scene play is made of events and the subject matter revolving around Pastor Oscar, a young vibrant Christian minister who insists on revealing the truth of the scriptures meant to be concealed from the congregation. Pastor Oscar, against the advice of the panel of senior partners of the church and that of his wife, to desist from his "gospel of truth, teaching and enlightenment" (Azunwo 41). Consequently, in his house, he is shot to death by an unknown gunman, bringing to an end Pastor Oscar's "plan to deliver a sermon about a new dimensional explanation of the recreation story..." (Azunwo, 35).

This paper examines the role of such linguistic devices such as irony and tension used by Azunwo in structuring the theme of the play which revolves around the consequences of the attempt to reveal the truth, The pursuit of career or calling against attention to wife and family, obedience to superior authority against individual self-will and obstinacy, etc.

The linguistic devices of irony and tension will guide the explanation of the play, as tenets of New Criticism. For more information, New Criticism rests on the concepts of paradox, irony, ambiguity and tension to achieve autonomy and self-sufficiency in a literary work. The New

Critics insist that literature has a special language considered figurative and opposite to that of science and ordinary language. Its procedure is close reading for the purpose of analyzing the complex relationships of words leading to ambiguities in a text; and believe that the main components of literature whether poetry, narrative or drama, are words, images and symbols, organized to achieve a theme. A high value of tension, irony and paradox (Abrams and Harpham, 242-243).

To engage in the analysis and explication of Azunwo's *Rabbi*, it is important and proper to explain such key guiding concepts of irony and tension and their relationship to paradox and ambiguity. Paradox, according to other Adagogo Brown, is a rhetorical antithesis which brings contradictory ideas or terms together at the structural level (14). William Empson, an English critic, is of the opinion that the three concepts of paradox, irony and ambivalence dwell on its economic fusion of two opposites but complementary meanings (Engleton, 45). Both Brown and Empson recognize the contradictory ideas, the complementary in one linguistic structure.

Although Empson jointly defines such terms as paradox, irony and ambivalence without a clear demarcation among them, Brown explains irony as a figure of speech that occurs when a speaker actually intends to say is expressed in words which carry the opposite meaning (11). As in Brown's definition, the word, "opposite", also recalls in Empson's explanation of the same terms.

Oye Ogubyemi expands the view of paradox by saying that it is a special kind of epigram, short and witty at first sight, seeming absurd and self-contradictory, yet contain some much truth (29). In all, the elements of oppositeness in paradox is further repeated in self-contradiction.

Although there are various forms of irony, including Socratic, structural, verbal, etc., it is important to note that what is common to all of them is the "oppositeness in meaning". As Ngwoke puts it, irony is a figure of speech in which the literal meaning is the opposite of the intended meaning (284).

Ambiguity is a very critical linguistic device cherished by the New Critics. William Empson is of the opinion that ambiguity occurs in "any verbal nuance, however slight, which gives room for alternative reactions to the same piece of language" suggesting that the "... Expression of a complex idea, not by analysis, nor by direct statement, but by a sudden perception of objective relation" (Udumukwu, 10-11). From Empson's impression, any expression in words, phrases, clauses and sentences and even a verse has the inherent tendency to offer another possible meaning to the reader or hearer. This development, Adagogo Brown summarizes, as the literary usefulness of ambiguity in enhancing richness and complexity in language (32).

The last of the concept in the tenets of New Criticism is "tension", which is believed to create a literary complexity of any text by linking together of opposites. Lois Tyson is of the opinion that tension is created by the integration of the abstract and the concrete, of general ideas embodied in specific images (123). In throwing more light on the concept of "tension", Tyson explains that the concrete image of universals of fictional characters, events, and environments are symbolic and represent other universal ideas. The creation of images in the literary works, which are of the universal symbolic significance is said to embody "tension".

In summary, Tyson sees paradox, ironies, ambiguities, and tensions does dynamic in the embodiments of opposing tendencies which must be harmonized in order to resolve the theme of a text; in terms of what the text does with its topic (123-124).

With the concepts of "paradox", "irony", "ambiguity" and "tension" properly explained their application in the explication of the text, *Rabbi* follows. It is important to point out that because of the nature of the concepts in embodying opposites or contradictions, there is a tendency for one expression to manifest two or more of the concepts.

Mrs Oscar's statement, "At least find time for us and let the Bible rest for once"(2), is both ironical and paradoxical. Although Pastor Oscar, the head of the family, has been providing for his family and also seen at home, Mrs Oscar appears to allege that the presence of her husband and the home is insufficient. The statement appears to contradict the fact that at the time of delivery, pastor Oscar is at home in terms of physical presence, while the truth is he has not devoted sufficient time to interact with his wife and children.

As the plot of the play unfolds, showing utterances, actions, events and subject matter, pastor Oscar's speech calls attention when he expresses apprehension and fear as pastor Jerry pays him an unscheduled visit to his office. In his shock of pastor Jerry's unannounced visit, Pastor Oscar asks, "I hope I'm safe?" (13). This question is loaded with anxiety, suspicion and portends ill omen. The triggers another question from Pastor Jerry to Pastor Oscar, "Do you feel unsafe?" (13) These exchanges by both Pastor Oscar and Pastor Jerry finally leads to Pastor Oscar's ironical statement, "I can't say, but by His grace, with you here, I'm safe" (13); this statement is not only ominous but also apocalyptic, a foreboding of the untimely death of Pastor Oscar. The irony in Pastor Oscar's statement at full circle manifest the opposite of his claim of being "safe" is Pastor Jerry.

From the encounter of pastor Oscar with the senior pastor Jerry to the meeting with a panel of senior pastors, the general council of the church, led by Pastor Tobi, pastor Oscar's agitation over his "ministration conduct"(24), Pastor Tobi asks Pastor Oscar, "Do you understand that excitement can also be a killer — if not slow — a very fast killer? (25) This question in one structure, embodies irony, paradox, ambiguity and tension. The question contains the elements of opposites and contradictions in the meaning of the words "excitement" and "killer".

Another ironical statement is embodied in another of pastor Oscar's statement, "... But there is nothing in this world made of man that will stop the gospel of truth, teaching, and enlightenment"(41). Subsequently, a gun made by Man kills pastor Oscar as reported in the stage direction: "(He walks to the door and opens it. An instant blast defines the stage as pastor Oscar falls to the ground lifelessly — the shooter unseen)" (44). The action from a gun made by man and the shot by an "unseen shooter", also a man, is antithetical to the earlier statement of pastor Oscar backed by his faith in the world of God in the Bible.

More irony is revealed in the statement by Tobi, member of a panel of senior pastors can general council at Pastor Oscar's church funeral service says to Pastor Uche, "Sincerely we all feel pained and sad about the way our brother died. And I tell you for free that no dedicated man of

God deserves to die in such a manner" (47). The above statement by Pastor Tobi is not only ironical but hypocritical, a contrived false appearance even when details pastor Jerry, "and I want to commission you to stop him... And if that is the case... go the extreme" (36) which suggest taking the life of Pastor Oscar, and he's eventual death, resulting from gunshot by The "unseen shooter" (44). As shown earlier, from the discussions of Pastors Tobi and Jerry, the latter is the Executioner who eliminates pastor Oscar at the instruction of the former.

Mrs Oscar says that her husband does everything well in a sentence that also suggest that he is lacking in giving attention to the family. She puts it this: "Honey, you do everything well... But at least, the little time you have should be for the family" (02). The statement appears illogical and contradictory, however, on a close examination, its embodies some truth of inadequacy on the part of Pastor Oscar. This is paradoxical. If pastor Oscar does everything well as his wife states, he would have devoted a little more time for the family.

Still at the or shadows visit of Pastor Jerry, he tells Pastor Oscar, "The thing is— you're an excellent man of God, career of Grace and deep understanding of His word. An honestly, ... I love your style" (14). The second and last sentence in Pastor Jerry's seeming confession, "And honestly, ... I love your style" is the opposite of his reason for visiting Pastor Oscar which is to inform and one him that in his act of preaching, "there is also something called disturbing about [his] style" (14). The contradiction in the earlier statement of Pastor Jerry, "I love your style" and the later "... There is also something disturbing about your style," amounts to doublespeak. Pastor Jerry's disgust and dislike of pastor Oscar's mode of preaching which is antithetical to his earlier claim, "... I love your style" is further contradicted by a later statement, "And you are doing it wrong"(18).

Finally, Pastor Jerry concludes his hatred for Pastor Oscar's style by telling him, "... I came here to speak with you— as a man I admire and like. Don't overdo it"(20). The note of caution and warning, reveals his dislike, contrary to his earlier confess love for Pastor Oscar's preaching style.

Attention should also be paid to Pastor Jerry's catchy parting prayer to Pastor Oscar, "Have a nice day — and remain blessed" (20). Even the above wish is also ironical, considering the fact that after all the expressions of bitterness about the style of pastor Oscar speaking and his final assassination by Pastor Jerry, the above prayer cannot be seen to literally portend good, except the opposite, evil and doom, conveyed both in speech and action.

Equally, to be noted is Pastor Tobi's answer to Pastor John's expression of fear about the possible negative consequences of Pastor Oscar's preaching style. In a reply to Pastor John's observation, "[Pastor Oscar] is going to be a serious problem" (31), Pastor Tobi says, "I don't think so. The Lord will take care of this. (Pauses) Ask Jerry to see me in the office soonest"(31). The preceding statement is both ambiguous and ironical. Rather than the Lord to take care of this problem, Pastor Tobi engages Pastor Jerry to physically neutralized Pastor Oscar. Instead of allowing God, a spirit force and essence, to deal with Pastor Oscar, Pastor Tobi, a human, contrary to his statement, assumes the role of God and direct the elimination of Pastor Oscar by Pastor Jerry. On his statement, Pastor Oscar, is a contrary human actor compared to God, a spiritual being. Pastor Tobi's switching of role and the assumption of the deity of God is ironical.

Even the last expectation of Pastor Oscar is expressed in an ironical mode, a structural irony, the introduction of a structural feature that serves to sustain a duplex meaning and evaluation throughout a work (Abrams and Harpham, 185). This manifest in Pastor Oscar's high expectation of a cheering information from an anticipated visitor, but instead, he is faced by an unexpected visitor at his door, who unexpectedly and contrarily brings him instance death by shooting. The structural irony begins with Pastor Oscars anticipatory and exciting statement "Oh... This boy is exactly here on time"(43). (Gets up) Yes... The planning committee Jefferson. Let me help him at the door."(44). Bees utterances embodying excitement and hope suddenly list to negative and sad action as pastor Oscar receives a gunshot that kills him instantly.

Azunwo continues his characters expressions in the ironic mode as Pastor Tobi pretends being shocked by the death of Pastor pastor Oscar which he masterminded. He planned the killing and knows the outcome which is the death of Pastor Oscar. Equally, he is happy that pastor Oscar has been eliminated. However, in public, at the morning of pastor Oscar he tells the congregation,

... It comes like a shock and so we can't question the cause of this. (Pauses) The Lord who gives has taken, and the Lord who made has recalled; and to the world he was given, he has been returned to glory. It is sad and painful, what has befallen our brother and friend."(46)

Pastor Tobi's declaration that, "[the death of Pastor Oscar] comes like a shock" and "it is sad and painful what has befallen our brother and friend" is the opposite of his happiness and satisfaction that he successfully masterminded the killing of Pastor Oscar. This is what Kelly Mays refers to us the echoing of characters feeling to mack his pretentious speech or thoughts to stating his action in formal diction, which shows discrepancies or gaps between vision and voice, intention and understanding, or expectation and outcome, thereby generating irony (160).

In the entire play, *Rabbi*, Azunwo assigns ironical utterances to Mrs Oscar, Pastor Oscar, Pastor Jerry and Pastor Tobi, who are the major characters around whom revolve the events, subject matter and the theme of the play. In arriving at the thematic concern of the play, the paper examines the interplay of opposing tendencies in the ironical utterances of these major characters. In alignment, Tyson adds that all the multiple and conflicting meanings which produces all the ironies and tensions must be resolved call harmonized by their shared contributions to the theme (123-124). Theme is an underlying meaning of a literary work which may be directly stated but more often implied, Akporobaro (403).

The major theme of the play bothers on the conflicts of opinions and interest on one hand, between Pastor Oscar and the General Council of his church over his insistence on the Gospel of truth, teaching and enlightenment, and on the other, Pastor Oscar, finding and giving quality time and attention to his family, which his wife demands. The conflicts, situated at pastor Oscar's workplace and home also operates at official and domestic levels. The language of irony, according to H.L.B. Moody is the use of words or statement in such a way as to convey and implication contrary to the stated literally (207).

Observing the play of contrariness as a common factor in irony, tension and the theme of the play, this paper concludes that Azunwo deliberately chooses these linguistic devices to

foreground or bring the theme of conflict to prominence. Like irony, ambiguity and paradox, tension is a linking together of opposites (Tyson, 123), for the purpose of highlighting the message of the text. In Azunwo's *Rabbi*, tension is created by the integration of the abstract idea of contention which Allen Tate refers to as "intention". (Abrams and Harpham, 400), observed in the killing of pastor Oscar by the General Council led by Tobi, to prevent him from delivering a sermon on a new dimensional explanation of the real creation story (35), and the concrete idea of the preservation of selfish interest of the group, the General Council, led by Tobi which Tate identifies as the "extension". By the creation of tension, Azunwo exposes the universal theme of conflict, the supremacy and rival group interest represented by the General Council over personal ambition represented by Pastor Oscar and his death occasioned by the former. The theme also suggests Azunwo's privileging of falsehood represented by the General Council over the revelation of the truth championed by Pastor Oscar. Also, the resolution of this theme suggests the privileging of evil over good, symbolized by the death of Pastor Oscar.

Equally of importance, though minor, is the all resolved conflict between pastor Oscar and his wife bothering on the accusation of the former by the latter, of inadequate family attention and care. This conflict the equally realized through ironical utterances, remains unresolved and overwhelmed by the major conflict. The playwright fails to take position on the conflict between husband and wife, thereby leaving the tension unresolved as characters do nothing, symbolic in advancing their individual personal interests and positions as observed in major theme.

The play, *Rabbi*, is a statement about the universal theme of conflicting interests. The major conflict of interest in the text operates at the corporate level in the church, manifested by the desire of the Tobi-led church General Council to hide biblical teachings, and Pastor Oscar's insistence on revealing the truth. The conflict is resolved in favor of the church General Council following their successful extermination of Pastor Oscar. This resolution also shows group victory over the resistance and fight by an individual. This major conflict integrates loyalty and rebellion.

The underdeveloped and unresolved minor plot is the conflict between Pastor Oscar and his wife over the former's inadequate devotion of interaction with his family. This very important domestic and family issue remains all resolved in favor of neither the husband nor the wife.

In the achievement of both the major and minor themes, Azunwo deploys the linguistic devices of irony and tension, the tenets of the New Critics. Azunwo exploits the inherent natural ambiguity and complexity of these devices to reveal the play's conflict of interests at corporate and family levels.

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